

- RAG Learning

3.8 Ecologism

Politics — AQA (7152) — Paper 3 (Political Ideas)

Ecologism is the only ideology to question whether **human beings should be the measure of political value at all**. That is what distinguishes it from environmentalism — which manages environmental problems within existing arrangements — and it is the claim on which its status as an independent ideology rests.

Optional ideology. Students study *one* of nationalism, feminism, multiculturalism, anarchism or ecologism.

AQA key thinkers for ecologism: Aldo Leopold, Rachel Carson, E.F. Schumacher, Carolyn Merchant and Murray Bookchin.

1. Ecologism vs environmentalism

	Environmentalism ("shallow green")	Ecologism ("deep green")
Value of nature	Instrumental — matters because it serves human welfare	Intrinsic — matters in itself, independently of human use
Approach	Reformist — regulation, technology, conservation, sustainable growth	Radical — fundamental restructuring of economy, society and values
View of industrialism	Manageable with the right policies	Industrialism and the commitment to growth are themselves the problem
Orientation	Anthropocentric	Ecocentric

2. Core ideas

Ecology and holism

Holism is the view that a whole is more than the sum of its parts, and that entities can only be understood through their relationships within a wider system. Scientifically it reflects the ecological insight that organisms and environments form interdependent systems, so intervening in one element has consequences throughout — the central lesson of Carson's *Silent Spring*.

Philosophically it challenges liberal individualism and the mechanistic worldview that treats nature as separable parts to be manipulated.

Anthropocentrism vs ecocentrism

- **Anthropocentrism** — humans at the centre of moral concern; nature has value as a resource, a source of beauty or a support system.
- **Ecocentrism** — the ecosystem as a whole has intrinsic value; human interests should not automatically take priority over other species or ecological integrity.

This is the principal fault line in ecological thought, because it determines whether nature is protected *for our sake* or *for its own*.

Sustainability

Meeting present needs without compromising future generations' ability to meet theirs. Note its implication: the interests of people who do not yet exist become a political consideration — something no other ideology accommodates naturally.

Environmental ethics

Extending moral consideration beyond humans — to sentient animals, to all living things, or (in Leopold's holistic version) to the biotic community as a whole.

Materialism, consumerism and post-materialism

Ecologists critique the assumption that more consumption means a better life. **Post-materialism** describes a shift in advanced societies towards valuing quality of life, environment and self-expression above material acquisition once basic needs are secure.

3. Key thinkers

Aldo Leopold (1887–1948) — *A Sand County Almanac* (1949)

- **The land ethic** — the moral community should be extended to include soils, waters, plants and animals: the land as a whole.
- **The standard** — an action is right when it tends to preserve the integrity, stability and beauty of the biotic community, and wrong when it tends otherwise.
- **Holistic, not individualistic** — moral standing attaches to the *community*, not to individual organisms. This distinguishes ecologism from animal rights philosophy.
- **Humans as plain members** of the biotic community rather than its conquerors.

Rachel Carson (1907–1964) — *Silent Spring* (1962)

- **Pesticides and ecological damage** — documented how DDT accumulated through food chains, devastating bird populations.
- **Interconnectedness** — demonstrated concretely that intervening at one point in an ecosystem produces unpredictable effects throughout it.
- **Challenging the authority of industry science** — she faced sustained attack from the chemical industry, which made her book a case study in corporate resistance to environmental regulation.
- **Significance** — widely credited with launching the modern environmental movement and leading to the US ban on DDT.

E.F. Schumacher (1911–1977) — *Small Is Beautiful* (1973)

- **Natural capital, not income** — conventional economics treats natural resources as income rather than as irreplaceable capital, so depleting a forest or fishery registers as *profit* rather than as liquidating an asset.
- **Human-scale economics** — smaller, decentralised production units serving human needs; "production by the masses, not mass production".
- **Intermediate / appropriate technology** — technology suited to local conditions and skills rather than imported large-scale industrial systems.

- **Buddhist economics** — the purpose of work is human development and satisfaction, not maximised output.

Carolyn Merchant (b. 1936) — *The Death of Nature* (1980)

- **Ecofeminism** — the domination of nature and the subordination of women share common roots in patriarchal thinking that devalues both.
- **The historical argument** — before the Scientific Revolution nature was widely conceived as a living, nurturing organism, an image carrying implicit ethical restraints on exploitation. The **mechanistic worldview** that replaced it recast nature as inert matter operating by discoverable laws, removing those restraints and legitimising systematic exploitation. The same period saw a marked deterioration in women's social position.
- **Dualisms** — culture over nature, reason over emotion, male over female: a single conceptual pattern underlying both forms of domination.

Murray Bookchin (1921–2006)

- **Social ecology** — the ecological crisis originates in **hierarchical social structures**. The domination of nature is an extension of the domination of humans by other humans.
- **Against deep ecology** — attributing the crisis to "humanity" in general obscures that particular social arrangements, and particular groups within them, cause and profit from ecological destruction while the poor suffer its consequences. He regarded misanthropic deep ecology as politically useless.
- **Libertarian municipalism** — directly democratic municipalities federated together; production for need rather than profit. Drawn explicitly from anarchism, so his position is often called *eco-anarchism*.
- **Positive view of humanity** — humans could become "nature rendered self-conscious", capable of caring for the biosphere deliberately.

4. Strands of ecologism

Strand	Diagnosis	Prescription
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Deep ecology	Anthropocentrism itself — the belief that nature exists for human use	A wholly new ecocentric ethic; radical reduction in human impact and consumption
Shallow ecology	Specific environmental harms damaging human welfare	Regulation, technology, conservation, sustainable growth within existing structures
Social ecology / eco-anarchism	Hierarchy and domination in human society	Decentralised, directly democratic, federated communities (Bookchin)
Eco-socialism	Capitalism's structural requirement for continuous accumulation	Replace capitalist production with production for need
Ecofeminism	Patriarchal dualisms devaluing both women and nature	Dismantle those dualisms; revalue nurture and interdependence (Merchant)

5. The critique of economic growth

- **Physical impossibility** — indefinite exponential growth cannot continue on a finite planet with limited resources and limited capacity to absorb waste (the *Limits to Growth* argument).
- **Growth is mismeasured** — Schumacher's point that GDP counts activity regardless of whether it creates or destroys value; pollution *and* its clean-up both increase it.
- **Growth stops delivering wellbeing** — beyond the point at which basic needs are met, further consumption yields little additional welfare.
- **Structural cause** — eco-socialists argue growth is not a policy choice but capitalism's requirement, since firms that do not expand are eliminated by competition.

The counter-argument: growth funds the technology and environmental protection poorer societies need, and decoupling growth from emissions is achievable — so the target should be the *environmental impact* of growth rather than growth itself.

6. Tensions within ecology

Disagreement	One side	The other
Source of value	Deep ecology — nature has intrinsic value; humans are one species among many	Shallow ecology — nature matters because of what it provides for humans
Cause of the crisis	Deep ecology — anthropocentrism and human numbers	Bookchin — hierarchy; eco-socialists — capitalism; Merchant — patriarchy
View of humanity	Deep ecology — at times misanthropic; humanity as the problem	Bookchin — humanity as potentially nature rendered self-conscious
Scale	Schumacher, Bookchin — small, decentralised, human-scale	Others — global coordination is required for a global problem

Exam Tip: Bookchin's critique of deep ecology is the sharpest internal dispute and should feature in any evaluative answer. Blaming "humanity" in general cannot identify *who benefits* from ecological destruction or *how to change it* — and a movement that treats humanity as a disease has no political programme. The reply is that Bookchin's ecology may be doing less work than his prior anarchist analysis.

7. Is ecology a distinct ideology?

Yes	No
Offers a complete worldview — an account of humanity's place in nature, a critique of industrialism and materialism, and a programme for restructuring society	Most of it attaches to other ideologies : eco-socialism to a Marxist critique, eco-anarchism to hierarchy, ecofeminism to patriarchy

Holism and ecocentrism genuinely break with the anthropocentric individualism shared by liberalism, conservatism and socialism alike	Only deep ecology makes a genuinely free-standing claim — and it is the strand with the least developed political programme
Generates positions no other tradition reaches — rejecting growth as an objective; the interests of future generations and other species as political considerations	Each strand's <i>politics</i> comes from its prior analysis of domination, not from its ecology

Exam Tip: The strongest conclusion draws a parallel: ecologism may be best understood like **nationalism** — a distinctive set of premises that must combine with a social analysis to generate politics, rather than a free-standing tradition like liberalism or socialism.

Key terms

Term	Definition
Ecologism	Ideology requiring fundamental restructuring of society around ecological principles
Environmentalism	Managing environmental problems within existing structures
Holism	The whole is more than the sum of its parts; entities understood through relationships
Anthropocentrism	Humans at the centre of moral concern; nature valued instrumentally
Ecocentrism	The ecosystem as a whole has intrinsic value
Land ethic	Extending the moral community to soils, waters, plants and animals (Leopold)
Sustainability	Meeting present needs without compromising future generations

Deep / shallow ecology	Ecocentric and radical / anthropocentric and reformist
Social ecology	Ecological crisis originating in hierarchical social structures (Bookchin)
Ecofeminism	Domination of nature and subordination of women sharing patriarchal roots
Post-materialism	Valuing quality of life and self-expression above material acquisition
Intermediate technology	Technology suited to local conditions and skills (Schumacher)
Tragedy of the commons	Individually rational use of a shared resource leading to its collective destruction
Natural capital	Natural resources treated as a finite irreplaceable asset rather than income